Infant Social Referencing Under Uncertainty

Late in the first year, infants can use a familiar adult's emotional signal to regulate approach or withdrawal in an ambiguous situation; referencing is not an attachment classification.

GRADE: HIGH-LAB; LOW-ATTACHMENT-VERDICT | STATUS: STABLE | DOMAIN: SOCIAL, REGULATION | REPLICATION: VERIFIED

WHAT WE KNOW (Narrowest Supported Conclusion)

When a situation is ambiguous, infants toward the end of the first year often look to a familiar adult's face and then approach or withdraw in line with that signal. On the visual cliff, Sorce, Emde, Campos & Klinnert (1985) found that most infants crossed toward a smiling parent and almost none crossed toward a fearful expression. Walden & Ogan (1988) traced referencing as a developing skill across the first two years, not a single switch.

EVIDENCE AND CAUSAL ASSESSMENT

The visual-cliff study is an experimental manipulation of the adult's expression with a physical setup that makes the drop ambiguous at a particular depth. That is stronger identification than a correlational "looks at parent more." It is still a laboratory task: the cliff, the toy, and the posed face are not a household. Walden & Ogan (1988) is an independent laboratory program (different lab, developing skill across the first two years, ambiguous toys rather than a cliff) — a conceptual replication of referencing under uncertainty, not a household-attachment study.

EFFECT SIZE AND PERSISTENCE

The classic result is categorical in a small sample (cross / not cross), not a portable standardized effect for "social competence." Persistence as a trait is not what the studies measure.

BIAS, HETEROGENEITY, AND CONFOUNDING

GI attenuation: n/a. Posed expressions, caregiver identity, infant locomotor status, and the experimenter's definition of "ambiguous" all shape the score. Stranger wariness can co-occur and is not this card.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT MEAN (Strict Boundary Conditions)

Does not mean stranger anxiety is insecure attachment. Does not mean a parent who shows fear has injured the child. A look to an adult is information use, not a purity test of the relationship.

WHAT ACTION IS REASONABLY JUSTIFIED

Ordinary presence of a trusted adult in new situations is consistent with the finding. Training parents to perform referencing, or treating a wary infant as an attachment failure, does not follow.

VERIFIED SOURCES & DOI IDENTIFIERS

- Sorce, Emde, Campos & Klinnert (1985), Developmental Psychology
- Walden & Ogan (1988), Child Development